

Stars and galaxies

THE CENTER OF OUR GALAXY 25,000 light-years from Earth

The center of our galaxy, the Milky Way, is thought to harbor a black hole as heavy as 3 million Suns. This image reveals flare-ups in X-ray activity close to the event horizon, the point of no return for any objects or light that approach the black hole.



CENTAURUS A 15 million light-years from Earth

Not all galaxies exist in isolation; occasionally, they interact. Centaurus A is far more “active” than our own galaxy. It has an even bigger black hole than the Milky Way’s, and its gravity may have captured and “cannibalized” a smaller neighbor.



THE WHIRLPOOL GALAXY 31 million light-years from Earth

The Whirlpool is involved in another case of galaxy interaction. A spinning, disk-like galaxy, viewed face-on, its spiral structure may have been induced by the gravitational pull of a smaller satellite galaxy (at the top of this picture).



THE ORION NEBULA 1,500 light-years from Earth

The Orion Nebula is a vast cloud of glowing dusty gas within the Milky Way, inside which new stars are forming. The nebula contains bright blue stars much younger than the Sun and some protostars whose nuclear power sources have not yet ignited.

